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Jake Hanna

Drummer Jake Hanna has been the spark plug behind some of this country's hottest jazz ensembles. A native of Boston, he was born on April 4, 1931 and received his first drum lessons from Stanley Spector. In the mid 50s, Jake played with a succession of jazz stars including Woody Herman, Marian McPartland and Maynard Ferguson. He has had a steady career on both coasts, moving to Los Angeles in 1970 with the Merv Griffin Show. His lengthy list of recordings include work with SuperSax, Oscar Peterson, Herb Ellis and Carl Fontana. Jake is the subject of a chapter in Marian McPartland's book All in Good Time. *He continues to lead a busy schedule of recording and appearances at jazz clubs and festivals.*

Jake was interviewed at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 11, 1997, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Aspen, Colorado, filming for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I've been waiting for this for quite a while now. We're filming with Jake Hanna, one of the great jazz drummers and conversationalists.

JH: Conversationalist, yes. I love your name, Monk. I'm going to start using that name, Monk Rowe. I've been using Sneed Hern for years. But Monk Rowe, that's a hell of a name. I never heard a name like that either. Thelonious Monk was far out, but Monk Rowe.

MR: I'll be expecting some checks in the mail though if you start to do that I think.

JH: Oh, yeah, yeah, good. I'll send you back yours if it bounces to me it'll bounce back to you. Sounds like basketball.

MR: Oh, my. I'm going to read something here—

JH: All right.

MR: Okay? That you told to a very famous lady. You had three childhood heroes: Brace Beemer—

JH: Brace Beemer, The Lone Ranger. Ross Tompkins knows him.

MR: Okay. Benny Goodman—.

JH: B.G., yeah.

MR: And Ted Williams.

JH: Big Ted, yeah.

MR: Now, what happened to Brace Beemer?

JH: Brace passed away. I think he moved to Florida, well yeah, he moved to Florida, because Ross Tompkins' father knew him in Detroit. And I think he died. I think he took over that Lone Ranger Show.

MR: We should tell our viewers who he was, in case they don't know.

JH: Well he played the part of the Lone Ranger. He actually produced the show originally I think and somebody else played the Lone Ranger. They all started leaving and going somewhere else. So he just took over the role, plus the show. He was a very popular guy I guess. "The Lone Ranger, played by your announcer Brace Beemer." So maybe two guys did the whole show, who knows.

MR: And of course Ted Williams.

JH: The best, yeah, the best. The King of Swing. A real King of Swing. I'll tell you, he was really something. Yeah I liked him because he was like a salmon, you know, like Buddy Rich, he swam upstream. Everything was coming against him and the press was one hundred percent against him. Not the press, but a guy named Parker, Colonel Dave Parker, a real bad apple. And Ted just frumped them all, and one and one, and beat them all down, yeah. Just single handed. You know, fantastic. They pulled a shift on him, you know, still the most ferocious shift ever pulled on any ball player. They had one for Stanley Musiel too, a hell of a hitter too. But they all did — everybody was over to the side, all the fans, everybody got over to one side of the field. The dogs, the cats, the guys that sold the hot dogs, they all got over to one side. Mondello — Tootsie Mondello's father was a hot dog salesman, and he got over on the right side. And he hit again them, it threw them. And who the hell wants to see him hit over there to left field? But he did, one time they were playing Cleveland and they all pulled over and he popped one over the left field wall which was a very short fence anyway. He said, "See I can do that anytime I want." They said, "Yeah, we know that." Bob Lemon tells the story, he could hit to the left anytime he wanted, but who would go to see him? They wanted to see Superman. That's what he was, Superman.

MR: Well, and Benny Goodman.

JH: B.G., yeah. Yeah, he was great, great. He never cared for me, but gez, I heard some fantastic things he's done. Still, even now, you'll bring back some old things he did. My wife and I were listening to him on a tape, 1935, 1938 with Gene and Teddy. They had to divide it up and it was much better as a trio, it really was. They could do whatever they wanted you know? They didn't have to worry about getting the keys right in the middle of a song, just look at Teddy and Teddy looked at him and they knew just what they were doing. We're trying the same thing with Kenny Peplowski and Johnny Varro and myself. We rarely get together but when we do it's very exciting, very exciting. They're great. The guys are great.

MR: How does it change your playing to work without a bass player?

JH: Well you adjust the playing. Sometimes I just leave the hi hat off. And you play off the snare and the bass drum stays very steady. You've got to re-tune it where it gets a nice tone. And it all depends on that piano player see? You've got to have a nice, loose left

hand. Can't be pounding. Teddy can play you know. There's only one Teddy Wilson. And that's Johnny Varro. But Johnny is very good, absolutely. And Ralph Sutton. We have a good, easy time with Ralph and we have an easy time with John Bunch, and Dave McKenna, he's born for that, Dave McKenna is the king of that stuff. In fact he doesn't need us. So the hell with Dave.

MR: Oh, my. Well you're a Boston — raised in Boston?

JH: Dorchester, yeah, Dorchester, Mass, yeah.

MR: And Stanley Spector?

JH: Stanley was around Boston, yeah. He eventually moved to New York. I studied a little bit with Stanley, not that long. He got my reading — sort of got my reading up a little bit, which I never bother with. You can't see the notes, what the hell's the use of reading? You still have to play by ear and I hate playing with big bands anymore, they're just over-written. You know the arrangers have taken everything — it's like watching a movie where the cameraman is now the director, you know? What the hell kind of a movie is that, you know? I had a friend that was a movie actor, Jimmy Flavin from Portland, Maine. You've seen a lot of him, he made four movies a day sometimes, from Warner Brothers, yeah. Two seconds here, one minute there. Go over and do "Mildred Pierce" over here, "Okay, what do I have to do?" Just say, "Guilty" or something like that. Then he'd go over and, what was the other one he was in — he made four in one day. But it's only short parts. He did "Yankee Doodle Dandy" and he just looked up and says, "It's a boy," okay that's it, then he gets out of the fireman's uniform and goes over and plays a detective. And he'll do that thing for Laura, okay, we'll do that one where Laura stands on the sidewalk, and that's it. Very famous character actor, Jimmy. Contract player they call him. But anyway, go ahead.

MR: Well we were talking about actually how you got started with big bands, but Woody Herman was your first big band?

JH: No Ted Weems was my first big band, yeah, Ted Weems was. And then I played in a very good band after that, Buddy Morrow had a very good band when I worked with them, it was way better than Woody's band that he had at the time, very good. Kenny Peplowski worked with Buddy. And he said the same thing. He says he's a great guy to work with and always had a good band. But the band I was with was Dave on piano and Dick Johnson on alto, and Ray Diceo, and Rick Davis, a very good tenor player. We had a very good band, a very good band. And we played rhythm & blues both, oh I forget what the tune, "Night Train" naturally, that was his most famous record. And a lot of other tunes, "Red Top" and things like that. But the big band arrangements, they were fun to play, fun to play.

MR: At what age were you inclined to think, hey maybe I can make a living as a drummer?

JH: Well I never did anything else. So I never thought of it, never thought of it. Just loved it. I never thought of ever doing anything else. Ever. I just loved it. When I went in the service, I figured well I'll go in, I'll be a gunner, you know. But they eliminated them gunners, in the 50s, they eliminated it, everything was electronic. And they came up with the jets then, jets were invented. So they wouldn't let me handle a gun anyway, you know. But if you played a musical instrument they put you right in band play, and if you were a doctor or in medicine they pulled you right into that area and gave you a commission. You can't train a musician in four years. You just take somebody off the street and say all right you're in the service? Oh, you're going to be — I need two drummers over here — forget it, you can't train a guy you see? Who plays the drums? You do? Over here. A doctor? We can't train a doctor in four years. So you're automatically in when you go in. That's automatically what you do. Most people, they can train you. Infantry, everybody can shoot a gun.

MR: That's true. I never even thought of it that way.

JH: No they have to have specialists, and you've got to go right away. They can train guys in dots and dashes and radio people, they can get that done in six months you know. But not a musician. Play a march and then play a little dance job and play a show. In fact most musicians can't do all that you know, really.

MR: It's true. So you got to play during your service?

JH: Oh yeah, yeah. In fact I went in to do that. Because I wasn't good enough to play outside. And out of high school I really didn't know how to do anything. So I says I'll go in the service, see if I get in the band, you know, took a chance. Loren Moralis, a friend of mine and drummer, he got me in to the band, because I couldn't read you know. And eventually I learned to read off of trumpet parts and things, and the guys in the new band I was with in Texas, they showed me how to read, and quick. I learned how to read in a couple of days, really.

MR: You went right out of the service into a group in Texas and —

JH: I went out and I went down with Tommy Reeves band.

MR: I heard you made a lot of money there.

JH: Oh, a hundred a week. What was it — no, no, no, it paid ninety a week, ninety a week, sorry, ninety. Maybe sixty, maybe it was sixty a week, and then it went up to ninety five when we worked at the Statler chain. But I was always broke, you're always broke. And then I went with Ted Weems right after that. And we had a good time with him. He was a great guy, great guy. Gee he was just the nicest guy you ever met. Funny. Real funny and real loose. Him and Woody were the funniest guys I ever worked for.

MR: Yeah.

JH: Yeah. Real funny this guy. Very nice, warm hearted guy you know. Quite a modern band, besides the "Heartaches" thing we had to do every night, he had good arrangers. He kept the band right up.

MR: Besides the what thing you had to do every night? "Heartaches" is that what you said?

JH: "Heartaches." That was his big hit. From the 30s.

MR: That's right.

JH: He always kept playing it. That's what kept him in business.

MR: That's no different from some of the rock & roll bands.

JH: Oh, well Woody Herman, he played the "Woodchopper's Ball" every night. Yeah. We played Carnegie Hall one night and he says, "You notice something tonight at the fortieth anniversary?" I said, "No." "We got away without playing the 'Woodchopper's Ball.'" First time he's ever able to do it in about 30, 40 years.

MR: Wow. On the anniversary concert. Oh my. Well I've been reading a little bit — Marian McPartland wrote a whole chapter about you.

JH: Yeah. She's terrific, one of the best people I ever worked with. One of the most enjoyable times in my life.

MR: You told her that in late '59 you were playing in Storyville with Buck Clayton and Jimmy Rushing?

JH: Yes. That's right. That's right. Jimmy was the singer, Buck, Vic Dickinson, Pee Wee Russell, Bud Freeman. That was the four front line. And Lou Cotto and myself or sometimes George Wein, myself and Champ Jones, who worked for the police department. And the other band was Gerry Mulligan Quartet with Art Farmer played trumpet and Billy Crow and Dave Bailey. You know Dave Bailey wound up being a pilot for F. Lee Bailey, who was a flier himself.

MR: No kidding.

JH: Yeah, he was a pilot for him. He was a Tuskegee Airman, that's what Dave was.

MR: Was that a particularly significant gig for you?

JH: Yeah, yeah. It was so good I was walking to work one night, I'd been in there with Anita O'Day, I'd been there with the Hi Lo's, I'd been there with Lambert, Hendricks & Ross, you name it. I was there with these people [inaudible]. I walked in there one night and Sammy Margolis was sitting at the bar and he says, "You playing drums on this job, Jake?" I says, "Yeah, I am, Sammy." "It's going to change your life." I says, "You think so?" He says, "Yeah. It'll shoot you off in another direction. You'll never play that corny bebop stuff again." I says, "You think so?" I says, "Yeah, okay." I got up and boy was he right. That Buck Clayton was so easy to play with and comfortable and Pee Wee was great, a lot of laughs, and Bud Freeman was there and Vic Dickinson was one of the greatest of all time. It was so easy I didn't have to do anything. They just played it for us,

oh, this is how it's supposed to go. Everybody's supposed to contribute. Not like that battling and battling of Maynard, you know, and guys run up and down, trombones and all that, oof, Jesus. Yeah, this was great.

MR: I find it curious the fellow called bebop corny.

JH: Yeah they got pretty corny those guys. Not Charlie Parker, gez, I mean he was a monster or Conte Candoli, have you heard Conte?

MR: Yeah.

JH: I mean that's phenomenal. But most of those bop guys were corny, man, they didn't swing or anything. It just sounded like they didn't know what they were doing. And I don't think they did. No these guys were superb, you know, superb. But these guys played what they called bop I guess, Sonny Berman and Red Rodney, they were some superb players. But the other guys that played the bop thing that I was associated with was corny man, it was corny. It was awful, Jesus.

MR: Well you eventually went and played with Marian.

JH: Yeah. Well I went into Swing music forever. I never went back to the bebop thing. Never went back to it, I never went back, no. I went out with Marian, right after that I went with her trio, for years. I was in the Hickory House for years with Toshiko you know. I was with Maynard Ferguson at Birdland and things like that. Once I got with these guys, that was it. That was it. I headed for John Bunch and Count Basie, playing with Count in a little combos you know, oh, Dave McKenna, and after Marian I went right with Bobby Hackett. They hired me when we were in Ohio. He says, "Get back to New York and you come over and work at Condon's with us. It'll pay way more." And anyway, to work with McKenna, you know, beautiful. Then we added Bob Wilber and Cutty Cutshall and we went out and we always had that good quartet, you know.

MR: Well do you know what it was about your playing that they liked?

JH: Don't know. Don't care as long as they hired me.

MR: Don't try to analyze it.

JH: No, no, no, no, no don't analyze it at all, no not at all.

MR: Well you said, "To me freedom is gained through limiting your playing, disciplining yourself. Some modern drummers don't play with license."

JH: They play with reckless abandon I guess they call it. Arthritic abandon, that's what they call it. Arthritic abandon. Oh they were too busy. Too much noise going on you know. You eliminate all that and you get the good feeling, right with the bass, get the piano player to stay out of the way, and the horn player's got a chance. Now if he starts playing too busy, get another horn player, you know. You can hear the difference. When Kenny Davern starts playing, now the time starts swinging. It starts swinging man, very precise. You've got to think about it. Woody Herman says it's not that easy to explain. You just

don't fluff it off by saying oh you either swing or you don't. It isn't that easy. You have to think about the thing. Concentrate. A lot of concentration.

MR: Well I really enjoyed listening last night because I noticed that as each horn player got to do their thing, that you would vary what you were doing.

JH: Yeah. I'd slow down or speed up, you know.

MR: Just to get people's attention.

JH: Oh yeah. Drown them out, it's too loud here, too quiet here. Sure. Yeah. Well all the guys here have very good time, you know. Joe Temperley is fantastic. You know he's really a hell of a player, that guy.

MR: I know but you'd move from sticks to brushes, to hands. You know, whatever it took.

JH: Well that was a little solo thing I did.

MR: But I noticed, when you're playing behind Dan, that you added some muscle, and when it got to the piano solo, that you went way down.

JH: Well piano players — McKenna and Ralph — I mean that's two Charles Atlases in a row right there. That's strong players. Ross Tompkins got it all down, you know. That's strength. Ralph doesn't need anybody and neither does Dave. They're an entity. They're phenomenal those guys.

MR: So instead of trying to battle with their strength, you let them take it.

JH: Oh, yeah, yeah, follow them. Just join in, have a ball. It's like playing with Count Basie. Just join in, nothing to it with him. He was the easiest guy— Teddy Wilson, another guy, very easy to play with, very easy to play with. Just tag along man, that's all, have a ball, enjoy his music. I was a customer to him, you know, a paid customer. I'd sit there and I'd play the brushes, and no other idiot drummer could get up there and screw him up. I just played very simple behind him. But Dahlender was very good with him and Jo Jones of course was absolutely phenomenal with Teddy. But then again Jo tried to take over that one too you know. That's why Basie got rid of him, and that's why Teddy had to get rid of him. Too bad too. He was the best of them all I guess.

MR: Was it his ego?

JH: Oh, yeah, yeah. No he was not a shy guy. Not shy at all.

MR: Not shy like you.

JH: No, not shy. He was a very good pal of mine. Six days a week I'd hang with that guy.

MR: Oh, my the list goes on and on. You played with Ellington, and —

JH: I was just a sub for Sammy, it was only ten days with Duke, I subbed for Sammy.

MR: Now you made a comment that you felt you didn't play good with Ellington 'cause you were listening too hard.

JH: No I didn't play well with that thing, no, I didn't play well at all with that. Especially when Duke was conducting. He goes like this you know. He looked like a knuckle ball

pitcher up there, you wonder when he's going to let the band start coming in. I didn't know what he was doing. When Harry Carney beat off the tempo, I sounded like a million bucks with those guys. You know, he'd just go one, two, three, four, and man in you go. But Duke was like, whew, like whirling dervish. I said what's he doing? What's he doing? He says don't worry, Harry will get the tempo for him. And then Harry would bring me in. But if Harry wasn't beating the time off I didn't know what I was doing. Keeping my eye on Ray Nance you know. Ray goes bing — that's his one — okay, here we go. But I was not successful with that band. I was successful with Woody. I did okay with Harry James.

MR: Well tell me about in the 60s, you moved out to L.A. in '70?

JH: '70.

MR: But before that you got into the Merv Griffin?

JH: Yeah. I joined Merv in about '65. I left Woody in the World Series '64. Cardinals-Yankees, Reno, Nevada, '64. I watched the first two games there, then took a day off, flew back to New York and caught the next three games, and I bet on the Cardinals, and they won it that year, they did, they won it.

MR: Was Stan Musiel playing then?

JH: No, Stanley was not playing then. Kenny Boyer was playing. That was their big gun, Kenny Boyer. Short and third. Short, no. He was a great player. They had a good team, a real good team. The announcer now was playing then. I forget his name. He announces the World Series now. He was catching for them. What the heck is his name? Tim McCarver. He was with them. He was good. Tim was a good player.

MR: Well how did you like working a steady thing, a T.V. show every day?

JH: Oh, I hated it. Just hated it. And then I went out to the coast and he tripled the money. The money was lousy in New York believe it or not. And we went out to the coast, and he more than tripled it. So we made good money out there. But it was even worse. It was awful. It's a Sonny & Cher world out there, that television. It was people with no ability at all and no talent at all. Did you happen to watch the thing the other day, Quincy Jones trying to teach Bruce Springsteen and the poet/singer, what the hell's his name, Dylan.

MR: Bob Dylan?

JH: Trying to show them a song. These guys, well you might as well try to talk to that wall to get these guys to hear, they're totally deaf. It was the most embarrassing thing I've ever seen. "Honey come in here. Watch this." And my wife started laughing, I started laughing, we called up people, "Watch these two idiots." Millionaires, billionaires these guys. They can't do anything. God they were awful. Then poor Quincy, he just said okay, fine you know. We'll just do it your way. Showing them the melody, they just couldn't get the melody. And so he goes, "Sing what you're singing. That will be the melody" you

know. Poor Quincy. He's dealt with these fools for years. And Phil Ramone is in with them too. You know he's the best sound engineer there is. I don't know what he's doing with these guys. Making a lot of money I guess. But he did a lot of great stuff with Woody you know. Great stuff. He's a hell of a nice guy too. But yeah, it was awful that stuff they were doing. And that's what used to appear on the show all the time. Monty Rock III. The Lovin' Spoonful. And what was a couple of others. Peter and something or other, no, when the Beatle thing was going on.

MR: Peter and — Chad and Jeremy, Peter and Gordon.

JH: Peter and Gordon. Oh, man, I mean they were awful.

MR: And you had to play behind them.

JH: Oh yeah, and, "No that's too—" and, "well don't try to fix it up fellas" the trumpet player says "just play it as bad as they want it. I told you it wasn't going to be fun." And this is awful. Then Benny Goodman would come on and it would be fine. Count Basie'd come on, it was a great show. Bill Watrous got him to come on, the trombone player.

MR: Who was in the pit, in the show band?

JH: In New York we had Billy Watrous, Danny Stiles and Bill Berry. Then we added like Ziggy Harrell and Roy Eldridge, and on sax we had Roger Pemberton, tenor, Shelly Gould, and Richie Kamuka. Then Richie had to figure out whether to add Zoot Sims or Al Cohn, then Jim Hall was the guitar, and he took off and we got Jim Raney or somebody like that. And Jimmy refused to play any of this rock & roll stuff for Sonny. He refused to do it. So they brought in another guy. So now we had two guitars. Chuck Wayne and Jim Hall. Chuck Wayne refused to play. Now we've got two guys that refused to play the stuff. So you never heard so many bossa novas in your life with two guitar players going out. That's how we got around it. It was just awful. Art Davis, bass, myself, and Mort Lindsay was the band leader. Trombones, Watrous and Brookmeyer. It was crazy. Out at the west coast they had different guys. They had Herbie Ellis and Ray Brown, myself, that was the rhythm, and Jack Sheldon, put on Pete Candoli and Bill Berry. It had a nice band, a nice band.

MR: Nine years you did that.

JH: Yeah, nine and a half years. Almost ten years. Jimmy Cleveland was with us out there. Kai Winding. A very, very heavyweight band. One of the best on television, ever. But playing nonsense.

MR: But you put four or five hours a day into that show?

JH: Oh, yeah.

MR: Yeah. You were able to get out and do other things?

JH: Well you'd go to work at three and get off at eight. So that's five hours.

MR: But then was there a jazz scene in L.A. that you could tap into at that time.

JH: Well Donte's was going then, and a lot of the guys worked that place for nothing you know. Twenty-five bucks a night, if you wanted cash. If you wanted to get a check you could get thirty-five but it probably wouldn't, the check would probably bounce. That's how silly it is you know. Joe Pass used to work, you know, the best guys. Red Norvo. But if Red was there you'd get money you know. Or Basie'd come in or Zoot would come in, I worked with Zoot or Red. But I hardly ever worked there with anyone else. Some of the sluggers come in, Ross Tompkins or Teddy Wilson would always ask if he could have me you know. And that was okay. It paid nothing you know. Paying nothing.

MR: A couple of times the subject has come up about playing on top of the beat, playing behind the beat. Does such a thing exist?

JH: Well if you play on the top you rush. If you play behind you drag. Now if the rhythm did that, if they laid back, they'd be dragging see? If the band goes, "Well we're going to lay back." "Well we'll join you." "Oh, no, no, no, it'll slow down." And everybody played right in tempo, like Count Basie does. Basie's band, do they lay back? I says no they don't. Play the records you can hear the rhythm drop out. They go swinging straight ahead. Basie never allowed that. He always had Sweets Edison, Buck Clayton and they were right on the money man. Snooky Young. The best, the best. Oh, Lester Young. You know, who's better than those guys? The guys were right on time. Man, they don't lay back of the beat. They're dragging, that's all that is. You can't get swinging if you do that. You can't get swinging if you double time the medium tempos either. Those guys were always swinging. The band was always swinging. They were right on the money, right on time.

MR: You've played on hundreds of records I would think.

JH: I only got paid for a couple though.

MR: A couple of them. Still get those royalty checks coming in?

JH: No. Oh, I do from some of the Concord stuff.

MR: Yeah?

JH: We signed a deal years ago. But we didn't get much in front to do it, in fact they're making more now then I made then, on occasion you know. On occasion. But I got some good guys with that company. Alfred Turner you know. But we only made one record. But it sold very big. It was one of his better selling records. Rose Clooney, Crosby, Bing Crosby. I got them all on one record. Woody, Bing, Tony, Rosemary all on one record. Plus it was Scott Hamilton's very first record date with that company. The first record date he ever made.

MR: He was around 19 or something?

JH: No he was 22. I was listening to some old Woody Herman things we did in 1962. Sal Nestico was 22 years old then too. Boy was he wailing.

MR: Monster.

JH: 22 years old, I couldn't believe that guy. A monster.

MR: Was life on the road a hassle? Was it hard?

JH: Oh yeah, that's when you used to look forward to going to the gig you know. That was great. With Harry James it was very easy, you had the nice bus and nice things and everything was taken care of. But you never looked forward to going to the job. But with Woody Herman you looked forward to going to the job if he could find it. Because if all the band could find it at one time. Buddy was never there and all that but who cared, it was terrific music. Very exciting music. It set the world on fire there for about a year. With other bands, it's very comfortable, nothing happened though. Nothing ever happened.

MR: Who was the rhythm section with the Herman band with the first herd?

JH: When I was there there was only three guys, and we were there forever. Nat Pierce, Chuck Anderson and me. They're both dead now. Chuck just died a few months ago. But that's all there was, three guys. We never changed. And when I left it stayed the same, Ronnie Zito come in. So they stayed the same then.

MR: Did they call that the "second herd?"

JH: No they just called it the "swinging herd," that's all. It had a nucleus, it was Bill Chase, Sal, myself and Nat and Chuck and that's all we had. It was about four or five nucleus, if we could keep Sal all the time, it was hard to keep him in the band you know. But if he was there, he was the clean up hitter you know, he was the Babe Ruth. He was the attraction really. He was the attraction.

MR: Upstate New York guy, wasn't he?

JH: Yeah, Syracuse.

MR: There were some good players that came out of there. Romano and —

JH: Oh, the wise guys. The upstate upstarts, yeah. There was Menza, Romano — he was the biggest wise guy of them all — then Larry Covelli, Sal, Sammy Noto. They were real — Sal Nestico, Joe Romano, boy he's a real wise guy. He worked with Gap Mangione, Chuck's older brother you know, playing the piano and Gap, playing the piano. Joe takes a handkerchief and he throws it right across the keyboard like this. "What the hell is that for?" "Illegal use of the hands." A real wise guy. "Watch out man, I used to be a fighter you know." He says, "Well take the boxing gloves off when you're working with me, huh?" No use trying to top Joe. Might as well keep your mouth shut and let him — he used to do that to Buddy Rich, of all people. And Buddy Rich would come right back at him, and those two guys were funny when they'd get in the trailer or in the back rooms. You'd listen to those guys go at it, they were funny man. Oh, they were funny. He loved

him. Buddy Rich loved Joe Romano. Anybody that was a real quick wit he loved. But Joe could blow you know, Joe's a hell of a player.

MR: Yeah, sure.

JH: You just can't be funny, you've got to play too. Like Buddy could play like a demon. But he was a very funny guy. Jesus, he was a great guy, great.

MR: That's interesting. I didn't know anybody had the nerve to try to top Buddy Rich.

JH: Oh yeah. A guy named Jimmy Mosher was with him too. And Buddy'd get so mad he'd throw the sticks at him. But Jimmy always had a funny line, a funny comeback, and nothing he could do you know. They were funny guys man.

MR: Oh, man, you played with SuperSax?

JH: Yeah, SuperSax, that's right. I was with them. I made a couple of albums with them. Three or four albums. They called me to come back and do another one. They had Lawrence Morro who was a very good drummer, but they were doing fast tunes and Lawrence was not quite up to that stuff. And they had to add trumpets, voices, a big orchestra, plus the SuperSax. Plus they're doing the old things see? And Don Lamond called me up one day and he says — no Ray Brown. Ray Brown call me up and he says, "Gee, how do you know when you've had it, when to get off?" Like a fighter. He never knows when he's had it and they always quit too late. He says, "How do you know that in our business, Jake?" I says, "Gee I don't know, I'm not ready to get through yet." Well they did these old tunes they'd done on the original records, we had to do some of them. I started repeating myself, I couldn't get anymore new things going. And I called Ray the next day and I says, "I think it's time for me to get off this stuff." Then I explained to him what we did, we did some old stuff. Re-did some old stuff, and man I couldn't make it at all. Couldn't hear it you know. I think it's time for me to get off. Time to retire. He says, "Yeah I do the same thing, I have a lot of trouble with that stuff. Stuff I could do years ago" he says, "I can't do anymore." I listened to a thing the other day, my wife played an old record "Hell Don't Your Apple Honey" we did live and it's [scats] about that tempo you know. And I played that on four-four when I played on that band, with 16 guys. And man I didn't get through eight bars of that thing.

MR: Yeah?

JH: No.

MR: No kidding.

JH: I've got to start practicing you know.

MR: Someone said something about you in the Herman band is that when you were with them they could play tempos that they had never been able to play.

JH: Oh Woody, yeah, Woody said that. And that was the only difference between me and the other guys, Dave and Don, he said, "Yeah we can play any tempo with Jake." He actually

could play any tempo with Don too you know. He could play any tempo, Don Lamond, he's phenomenal. He's the greatest big band drummer of all time for my money. And with Dave, he had two tempos. He'd either come down on the one or go up into the other. And once he got there, you never heard anything like that. But otherwise —

MR: This is Dave Tough you're talking about?

JH: Dave Tough, yeah. You had to glide into one tempo or go out into — he had two favorite tempos and he'd bring that band into one of those things by about the second chorus, it was roaring, once you get this time right there, he was phenomenal that guy. That's the hottest swinging drummer I ever heard. I never heard a guy swing that hard.

MR: Yeah. Woody said, "Jake is the first great big band drummer to come along since Dave Tough."

JH: Yeah? Wow. That's all right. I like Woody a little better now.

MR: Yeah.

JH: I don't mind he beat me out of that money. I don't mind that. It's worth it. Worth it he said that. I'd rather have the money, but anyway, I'm glad. Of course he didn't have the money to pay anyway, what the hell? He was broker than I was. We didn't know that though.

MR: Oh that poor guy had some problems, didn't he?

JH: Oh those people are merciless, the IRS. They're finally going after the IRS. It's about time. Oh they can get real mean you know.

MR: Okay, so if you had a drum student, could you define what it is to swing?

JH: The first thing I would do if I had a drum student, I'd send him right over to Snooky Young, and let's sit down at the drums and play along with Snooky Young and show him how to phrase. Snooky Young knows just how to phrase those big band figures. Then I'd send him to Dick Shanahan, to show him how to move the hands right you know. And then get rid of him.

MR: In other words you'd be a subcontractor.

JH: Yeah, that's what I'd do yeah. But I would show him how the hand moves when you play time, show him how to define that. And that's it. I wouldn't bother with too much else. I wouldn't bother with the reading, because you play better like this, off your reflex. See reflexes. Without the reflexes, better you sell shoes, really. You've got to have those reflexes. An athlete, a ball player, Ted Williams — he could hit so well so old. He kept those reflexes up. Yeah. He hit a higher average than any old guy that ever played baseball. A phenomenal guy. A friend of mine died the other — not a friend of mine, one of my favorite players — Johnny Vander Meer. He used to pitch for the Reds you know. A friend of my mother was an umpire. In fact he was the president of the umpire's association. He umped one of those games when he pitched two no-hitters in a row.

MR: Oh that's right, I read that. The only guy in history.

JH: He was the only guy to do that. I met Tom Holmes and his wife Vivian on a ship, and he hung out with my wife and — I hung out with them. He played in one of those — he saw one of those games, and he says this guy was just wild enough to keep you off the plate so you couldn't dig in against him you know. You son of a — crazy guy on the mound. And he was just wild enough and with enough control that these two games in a row, one against the Braves and one against the Dodgers, that he pitched two no-hitters in a row man. Nobody'd even come close to that. But he was a mediocre pitcher otherwise. He was pitching with a lousy team. The only teams in those days were the Dodgers and the Cardinals, that's it. The national league. They were the only two teams.

MR: You still a baseball fan?

JH: Oh yeah. I still like it, yeah, I'm enjoying the series. I like that good pitching but boy I guess the Braves got overrated against these guys down there. I think the guys managed a very good series. Cleveland. I think he really knows what he's doing. He always did. He knew what he was doing that guy.

MR: Well I wanted to ask you about a story I read from Bill Crow.

JH: Bill Crow. He's a beautiful guy.

MR: He was talking about a New Year's Eve gig that you played with Ralph Sutton.

JH: Ralph Sutton. Right here. Up the street.

MR: Oh it was here?

JH: Up the street, yeah, Sunnie's Rendezvous. I went by it today. I walked downstairs, it's still there. I don't know what they call it now. It's still there. It's must be a pizza joint now, but—

MR: This particular New Years Eve, something happened?

JH: Yeah well, we can't say that on the T.V.

MR: Yeah we can.

JH: Ralph was, well you know Ralph, he's always a killjoy with other people. He can't stand people. And they were all getting on their hats and ready to go, and he goes like this you know. And the whistles and they're starting up this stuff. And about quarter to twelve they're starting this noise in the joint. So Ralph comes out about ten minutes to twelve or five minutes to twelve, he goes into a New Year's Eve song, whatever, "Auld Lang Syne." And people are — "what?" They've got another five or ten minutes, and he goes into that, and he gets off the stand about five minutes or twelve and leaves these people sitting there and he never came back 'till about quarter past twelve you know. They had to celebrate New Years by themselves. And they're going like this, the people: "you got big nerve." And they're yelling "Happy New Year." Then another ten minutes. Then

Ralph was doing this. I held up a big sign like this. Fuck communism it says. Red White and Blue. And it was given to me by Cal Tjader. You remember Cal Tjader?

MR: Cal Tjader yet.

JH: He gave me that sign. I said well I might as well put it to use. Fuck the commies, screw the commies. And we got the big red white and blue sign with the stripes and stars and stripes. Ralph was hysterical. He just got off the stand and left these poor people to fend for themselves. Well we worked New Years with Ralph, Jack and myself, over in Germany. They flew us over for it. They gave us a lot of money, about two G's for the night apiece. My wife went over, first class, great. I had to come back to Taos, New Mexico, to work a thing up there you know, for a couple of weeks. So I had to come right back. I flew over, played, and came right back. The other guys stayed there for two weeks. Treated like kings you know. We went there, and the Germans, they stop at eleven thirty. And they all hang out and you'd dine and you eat and New Years goes right by. And that's how they celebrate their New Years. These particular guys did anyway. They were very, very wealthy guys. Very wealthy. Yeah, I mean from the 30s and 40s right through the war they were wealthy and that's how they celebrate New Year's Eve. They just stop and they all sit and eat shrimps and little delicate expensive, exquisite food. And my wife and I are ready to get going, and oh no, it was very subtle, very quiet.

MR: Much more civilized.

JH: Much more civilized. They had a period there where they were very uncivilized, but that's very overly civilized now you know.

MR: You had a couple of albums under your own name off and on?

JH: Yeah I did. One was a mistake. That was called "Jake Takes Manhattan" and it was supposed to be with Rosemary Clooney, although she didn't show she got sick. And so we just put it together as an album. It was all off the top of my head. We never rehearsed a note. But we did it as we went along. Carmen Leggio, a very, very fine player on that. Danny Stiles. Guys you never heard. But it was the first and sometimes the only record date with that company. And Mike Moore, and John Bunch. So we just threw it together. It came out great.

MR: Well Carmen's still playing.

JH: Yeah he is. I'd sure like to see him in action. See him at these parties or something. Boy he's great. Great, great player this guy. Funny guy. Very funny guy.

MR: Well let me play a little snatch of a tune here, and see if you can — one of the many records you've played on.

[audio interlude]

MR: You have any idea? Too many records?

JH: Well it was a great sax sound and trumpet.

MR: Yeah. That's from the Triangle—

JH: Oh, who were all those guys? Who are they?

MR: Well let's take a look.

JH: Yeah, that was a thing for Gus Johnson, for Gus Johnson.

MR: Randy Sandke —

JH: Oh, no wonder.

MR: Ralph, Chuck Hedges, Jake Hanna, Rick Fay, Dan Barrett.

JH: Dan Barrett, yeah, yeah. I know the trombones, the trumpet was something I don't — Randy — and he's playing even better now, you know that? Playing even better now.

MR: Strong chops.

JH: Oh, yeah. Man he's really got a good ear too. But do you believe Conte Candoli in there tonight? I never heard music like that for years, except out of him. Boy was he playing, ooh, man. Some player that guy. Some player. We were on a ship, Carl Fontana and him and Pete, his brother Pete, and Bob Cooper was alive then, Bob was playing, myself, Randy Sandke, Ross Tompkins. Yeah, they worked us a little too much on this boat you know. We were supposed to go once then back. But we were playing three times a day, and nobody ever showed up. But we were eating. Oh first, we got off the boat. We got off the boat. They're two idiots these guys, Carl Fontana and Candoli. Turner stood there "look at this big ship." The Ensenada. [inaudible] He says "Count" Conte Candoli "Count" he says. "Is thata you boat out there?" He says "Insanada ma boat." These two — we had to put up with these two all week long. And at suppertime we were eating and you had to write down what you thought of the food. I said excellent, excellent, everything was great, don't bother me. Count says "the food is terrible and the portions are too small." He's a funny guy. Oh, he's funny.

MR: Both the Candolis.

JH: Oh they're great guys, yeah.

MR: They were with Herman too, right? Were they on the band with you?

JH: Conte was about 16 when he was with Woody back in the 40s, with Dave Tough was the drummer. No he remembered him well. And then he went back with a bop band. I'll tell you a little story about Gene Krupa. The kind of a guy he was. Nothing was taken for granted. You know Buddy Rich worked so hard to be the king of the drums after Gene. But Gene Krupa was the king of the drums. He was the most famous drummer of all time. He put everybody where they are now. Nicest guy that ever lived. Buddy DeFranco said that too. He said he never worked with a better guy in his whole life this guy. And Red Rodney told me a story. He was with Gene for quite a few years you know. And he was the first guy he let play bop. He played whatever he wanted to play. He used to feature him in "The Man I Love" and he played bop. And then he says, "Hey Gene, I got

a chance to join Woody, you know, he's got a brand new band." And Shelly and all the guys, Don Lamond, whose ever there. I forget who was there. And he says, "Oh yeah, that's okay, Woody's got a helluva nice new band" he says, "okay Red it's a been a pleasure having you, I know you did a lot for me." He says, "You ever save any money? I know I'm giving you two hundred a week." You know and everybody else was making about a hundred and forty dollars. But he loved Red. "I'm only giving you two hundred. You ever save any money?" "Well no. I spend most of it but I got a couple of bucks so I can go get to join this." "Well I knew you'd blow it." He says, "Come on back in the back room." He brings out the filing things you know, full of these little pay envelopes. And he says, "I put away fifty bucks a week for you. I was paying you two-fifty but I only gave you two hundred." So he wound up with a couple of thousand dollars so he could go out and join Woody. That's the kind of a guy Gene Krupa was.

MR: That's a great story.

JH: Yeah.

MR: What's in the near future for you?

JH: Oh, we've got this, what have we got after this one? Next month we go to Japan with Harry Allen.

MR: You're going to Japan with Harry Allen?

JH: Yeah we've got him, McKenna, Mike Moore and myself. Then they've got, a real nice guy who lives near me, Kenny Burrell, Howard Alden, each with a trio, and then they play together, and then they've got a band with Nicholas Payton, some tenor player, good alto player, and Jeff Hamilton on drums, John Clayton, Mike LeDonne, they've got a hell of a, they've got a sextet there. They've got Helen Merrill and her little quartet, Terry Clarke, an old pal of mine, he's going to be playing drums with them. And let me see, then our band. So that's one, two, three, four groups. So we were going to open up with a half an hour of our music, and now it's down to 20 minutes. So Dave doesn't even want to go you know. But we'll get them over there. They're big on bebop you know, in Japan. But it's a nice concert thing. And we'll be there five days, and three of them are going to be in a club so that's pretty good. And we'll be able to do some playing.

MR: I hear they like jazz in Japan a lot.

JH: Yes they do. There's a contingent over here, 15 people over here. Yeah. And they're going to be there. They already made a dinner date. Always got to take us out now. "We go out this night?" "What do you mean, I haven't even eaten yet now and I'm still just trying to get my first course here." They're already trying to plan how to eat over there, now this is next month you know. The Japanese are strange guys. Funny guys man.

MR: Oh Lord. Well you've had a marvelous career in jazz.

JH: I've enjoyed every minute of it, most of it, most of it.

MR: Well nine years on Merv Griffin, you know.

JH: Well that wasn't anything, but it kept me off the streets. Because everything faded at that time. Everything, the bottom fell out. And now — at least parts of Europe, I used to go over there every now and then, and take off a week here and take off a — he was very liberal about that. Very nice about it. You can go anywhere or take off anytime you want, go anywhere you want. The job is yours when you come back. So that's the kind of a guy he was.

MR: Now who is that?

JH: Merv Griffin.

MR: Oh, Merv, yeah.

JH: Yeah, you can come back, do anything you want. I don't care what you do. Just get a competent guy you know. So it was great.

MR: Made it livable.

JH: Oh, yeah, yeah. We had a good band, good guys in the bands though. And he wanted all-star bands, he did. Mundell Lowe left he says, "I've got a great guitar player for him, but he doesn't have any hair." He wants all young looking guys. So Danny Stiles says, "this guy's the best." He brought him the *Down Beat* polls, and he says, "Well this guy won all the polls, let me see what he looks like." He brought him in it was Jim Hall. And he says, "Here's our new guitar, Jim Hall, come on out here, let's do a tune." So he and them just did a tune. He says, "You're hired." So another time came up, the band leader was always trying to get rid of some of the stars and get his guys on there see, like get rid of me and get his kid drummer on there. So one time out in L.A. we were out there and he wanted to get this other guitar player from The Tonight Show on there, who happens to be very good, but Herbie Ellis got Joe Pass to come in there. And so Herbie and I went out to eat one night after Joe had done the job, and Herbie says, "You know, Jake, Mort says Merv hated this guy because he had no hair." He was a bald headed guy. He said, "I just don't know what to do, gez, now Mort's mad at me and he wants to get his guy on there." I says, "Well if that's what he wants to do, you're listening to Mort, let's go to the source." He says, "Oh we can't talk to Merv." I says, "Who can't talk to Merv? Come on." And we left the Brown Derby and we went up backstage and rapped on the door and Merv was sitting right by the door and he opened it up and he was in a conference with about twelve guys. He says, "Hey Jake how you doin'? When'd you get back?" I says, "Just today, I just had supper with Herbie." He says, "What's this you don't like that guitar player he sent to me the other night? Joe Pass?" "Joe Pass? What do you mean? He's better than you are, Herbie." He says, "You better be careful who you send in here from now on. That guy's the greatest." I said, "See? This guy was lying all the time." See? Herbie says, "Jesus. Always go to the top." Well word got around that somebody was

dissatisfied or said that he was dissatisfied with him. "You come to me when you've got something to ask me, man. Don't ask somebody else." That's how he was. He was very good at that. Very good at that. Now don't fool with him, because he'll chop your head off. But he'd stick right by you you know. If he's your enemy you'd better leave, you'd better leave. No use hanging around.

MR: Right. What's your opinion of contemporary jazz these days?

JH: I don't know. I was — Not bad, but you know, for a second there, but Coleman Hawkins made a very interesting statement one time. Rock & roll. "What do you think of rock & roll?" He says, "There's nothing wrong with that music it just doesn't have the right people playing it. It's just straight eights." And sure enough he was right. You know this guy Elvis Costello? Well I'm watching a show one night and it's from Ronnie Scott's. It's got Chet Baker with Elvis Costello. I says, "What's this going to sound like?" So he says what Chet did, you know [inaudible] "I don't have to know the tunes, you just beat them off. But I don't want any drummer there. And I don't want any guitar player over there. I want a bass player, but he's going to play this, and I want a keyboard but he's got to play the piano. And I'll play all your rock & roll stuff with those instruments." And you wouldn't have believed how good it sounded. What he could make — he could make music out of like — knocking that lamp over. Chet Baker, an absolute genius, without even knowing it. He played so great I couldn't believe it. And Elvis Costello sang and it was very believable. And some of the most enjoyable music I ever heard, but he cut out the noise. You've got to eliminate all the noise and the noisy drummers and the noisy loud bass and the bass player was good. He could play it. He played all the rhythm, and that's what I think of the contemporary stuff. But if you get right guy playing it forget it. You can get space guys playing. I heard a thing, I don't know what it's called but I was riding in a car with Tony Bell who happens to be over here now. And he was driving Mike Moore to a job in England and he played the radio and they were playing this whole thing by Gary Foster, and Jimmy Rowles and they played "The Peacock" on there. And man it was great. Now if that's contemporary, I'm all for that. But you know, Jimmy Rowles , he could do that in 1944. That's what he sounded like then. That's how good he was. That beautiful tone. He was just an advanced genius. Period. Woody always thought that too you know. They were all going for Bill Evans' time, he says, "Well I had a guy that did that in 1944 you know." Telling Alan Broadbent, he says, "Who's that?" He says, "Jimmy Rowles ." This gal Diana Krall, you know her?

MR: Yeah.

JH: She gets a very nice sound on the piano and very good time. She's one of the best. But she's singing now so I don't know what that's about. But maybe that's how they're pushing her. But I think that's a contemporary player. She has a couple of good guys

working with her. But they don't have any drums, they just have a bass — Nat Cole voicings you know, uh, instrumentation, not voicing. And she was going to study, she was studying with Jimmy Rowles . And I played with them one night. Her mother and father said, "Will you play with them, play behind my daughter some night?" I said, "Sure, okay." So we played Donte's and she was very thankful. I says, "What are you going to do now?" She says, "Oh I'm going to Canada and study with Don Thompson." I said, "Aren't you studying with Jimmy Rowles?" She says, "Yeah, but then I got a scholarship to study with this guy." "You know what that's going to be like, honey?" She says, "Well no I hear he's good." I says, "It's going to be like stepping off the top of the Empire State Building." And I saw her about two years later and I asked her, "How you doing, how did you make out in Canada?" She says, "Oh it was very thrilling, it was just like jumping off the top of —" She never forgot that line. She's a funny gal. "Stepping off the top—" She says no you were right, Jimmy Rowles is where I should have stayed. I said, "Well right, this guy's a genius." A genius Jimmy Rowles . Crazy as the day is long. Very funny man, very funny guy. Very funny fellow.

MR: Well I'll tell you this has been a fascinating hour to speak to you.

JH: Well thank you, Monk.

MR: I enjoyed your playing as much as your talking.

JH: The Monk Rowe, I got a Sneed Hern and Monk Rowe. I just love that. Jez what a great name. Where'd you come up with that name? Monk Rowe. Is that your, maybe your folks gave it to you?

MR: No it's a nickname.

JH: From Thelonious Monk?

MR: Well no actually, from a big blue coat I used to wear.

JH: Oh, like a real monk.

MR: But it is my real name now.

JH: It is.

MR: If you insist on using it, you go right ahead, because I know you will treat it with respect.

JH: Well I've been passing myself off as Monk Eastman for years. I don't know if you ever heard of him. He was an old gangster out of New York. The old, very famous gangster. Dutch Shultz and Monk Eastman were very big rivals.

MR: No kidding. Well on behalf of the college I'd want to thank you for the time.

JH: Well my pleasure.

MR: I hope you have a good gig tonight.

JH: Now what town is this in New York?

MR: Clinton, New York. Hamilton College.

JH: Oh Clinton, New York. From the canal from the steamboat guy.

MR: No, from, yes actually he helped make the Erie Canal and so forth. It's named after Alexander Hamilton. The college.

JH: Oh, oh, oh, but the town is from the Clinton. So you've got a couple of good guys there. Not contemporary, but good. Very good guys, yeah.

MR: All right.

JH: All right, my pleasure.